

CHINESE GONGFU CHA

A celebration of the process as much as the product, the Gongfu Cha ceremony pays homage to the time and effort required to prepare a good cup of tea. A variety of teaware is used, ranging from decorative porcelain to clay, each with a specific function.

"Gongfu" is the traditional Chinese method of tea preparation. "Gongfu" translates as "time" or "effort," while "cha" translates as "tea." The ceremony involves great skill and is mostly performed by women, whose choreographed hand movements are carefully timed to the steeping of the leaves and the eventual readiness of the tea. Gongfu Cha is most often performed using the lightly oxidized oolong Tie Guan Yin (Iron Goddess of Mercy), although any high quality tea can be used.

There are two regional styles of Gongfu Cha: the more modest ceremony, from Chaoshan in the Guangdong province, which distributes the tea directly into the cups; and the other ritual from the Wuyi mountains of Fujian, which uses the chahai, or fairness cup, to hold the prepared tea before distributing it evenly among the cups.

Yixing teapots are the most popular choice for preparing tea for the ceremony. Made of unglazed clay, they absorb the aromas of the tea and, as such, are often reserved for just one type of tea. A combination of porcelain and glass teaware may be used for the serving vessels.

YIXING CLAY TEAPOT

This unglazed teapot, made from regional clay from Yixing, in the Jiangsu province, is rinsed with hot water to clean and warm it before tea leaves are added.

TEA STRAINER

Used to catch the leaves while pouring the tea into teacups.

SCOOP

Used to add tea leaves to the pot.

NOSING CUP

This small cup is used to enjoy the aroma of the tea before it is consumed.

TEA PET

This small figurine, made of Zisha clay and depicting an animal or mythical creature, changes color when hot water is poured over it. It is believed to bring good fortune to the tea ceremony.

TASTING CUP

Tea from the nosing cup is emptied into the tasting cup for the guest to drink.

